

I wanted to walk away, but the fellow wouldn't let me. Even though I had become a bit more tolerant of him lately, I certainly had no love lost for him.

'My rate stands, take it or leave it,' I said.

'The spread you have quoted is so wide that somebody could sell 50,000 shares of Apollo Tyres at this price,' Owl said.

By now I was really annoyed with him, and decided to insult him outright so that he would not prolong the discussion.

'50,000 shares eh? Well, if you have them on you, sell now. You have a buyer in me,' I said, fully aware that Owl did not deal in big quantities.

'Don't be so arrogant, Lala. I know you don't have the capacity to buy 50,000 shares. And you think you can make fun of me like that?' Owl said angrily.

I was pleased with myself now that I had managed to get him worked up. Somewhere during our conversation I recalled how he had managed to snatch at least two good deals from me. The memory of those losses made me want to inflict pain on him.

'You don't worry about whether I have the capacity to buy 50,000 Apollo Tyres or not; your concern should be whether you have those many shares to sell,' I said smugly.

I did not realize he was playing to a plan.

'Fine, Lala, I accept your offer. Sold to you, 50,000 Apollo Tyres,' he said, and quickly whipped out his *sauda* pad, noting down the deal.

I was stumped. It was true that I did not have the capacity to deal in 50,000 shares. While my boss had not specified any position limits, it was understood that I would not take excessive risks. After all, if the jobber defaults on his obligation, the broker has to make up for it.

I had taken Owl on because I knew that he did not deal in such large quantities either. Besides, it is common on the floor for traders to talk down each other so as to be able to get a competitive rate.

'Hey, wait . . . don't joke with such large numbers,' I said, realizing how perilous the situation could become, and hoping that Owl was just fooling around.

It was now Owl's turn to hurl barbs at me.

'Why, what happened, big man . . . did you just wet your pants at the thought of 50,000 shares? The way you were talking, I felt it was loose change for you,' he said, barely trying to conceal his glee.